Hacktoberfest 2026: from PR counting to events

Deep research report generated from public sources

Executive summary

- Hacktoberfest 2026 (October 2026) no longer counts pull requests or merge requests toward rewards.
- The old model was "open N PRs, earn a T-shirt."
- The new model centers on MLH- and DEV-run events, challenges, and participation stickers.
- Mission: "AI belongs to everyone"; DigitalOcean is presenting partner.
- Free to join for age 13+, subject to country and Fest rules.
- No official full participation totals were available mid-October; the best public counts were 531 Fests / 71 countries and 669,307 open hacktoberfest issues.

Quick facts

- Event window: October 2026
- Reward change: PRs and MRs do not count
- In-person scale: 300+ one-day Fests across 60+ countries
- MLH events API (mid-Oct 2026): 531 events across 71 countries
- Issue backlog: 669,307 open, about 517,632 unclaimed
- Repo index: 148,820 public repos under the GitHub hacktoberfest topic
- Online swag: mailed sticker pack at 3, 10, and 15 (or 17) virtual stickers out of 24
- T-shirt: not promised online; in-person supplies plus raffle items at select Fests

What changed and why

- Organizers say they are responding to maintainer feedback.
- AI made low-quality PR generation "trivial" while producing "no value."
- Maintainer burnout from large volumes of box-checking PRs is the stated reason.

Historical context

- 2020: 621,104 October PRs, with 9,598 spam/invalid and 172,599 sent to repos that never opted in.
- Reforms afterward included the hacktoberfest topic opt-in, hacktoberfest-accepted labels, and a 7-day review window.
- 2025: eligible-PR target rose from 4 to 6; T-shirt capped at the first 10,000 super contributors.
- OpenSSF-attributed estimate: about 35% of Hacktoberfest-labeled PRs were closed without merging.
- Registered participants fell from 169,886 (2020) to 56,768 (2025).
- Eligible PRs fell from 483,127 (2019) to about 87,929 (2025).
- One analysis argues the decline tracks tech labor-market contraction as much as event mechanics.

New event formats

In-person Fests

- Hack Day and Meetup Fests are one-day events.
- Hack Days run 3–12 hours and include demos and teams.
- Hosts get MLH funding/reimbursement; Meetups are community-run and unfunded.
- Participants may get certificates, swag while supplies last, and prizes at some Fests.
- Prizes include possible Hacktoberfest T-shirts and sensor-based Arduino projects.
- Mid-October distribution was uneven: India 224 Fests, US 101 Fests, with India and Bengaluru each prominent at 12 events or more.
- Some India events were invite-only with about 50 participants.

Online challenges

- Global Hack Week: Hacktoberfest (Oct 9–15, 2026) ran daily workshops, challenges, and Discord mini-events.
- DEV ran five challenges: one Weekend Challenge plus four weekly themes.
- Weekend Challenge deadline: Oct 4, 11:59 PM PDT.
- Weekly themes: Oct 5–11, Oct 12–18, Oct 19–25, and Oct 26–31.
- Typical prizes: Overall $250 + DEV++ + badge, Featured $200, category $100, plus completion badges.
- Central prompt: "Build something with open-source AI at its core."
- Partner credits included Tinker, Render, Backboard.io, and .tech domains.

Participation stickers

- Online participants earn 3, 10, and 15 (or 17, per MLH) virtual stickers.
- There are 24 collectible participation-driven stickers.
- The sticker pack is mailed after qualifying.

Issue and repository ecosystem

- 669,307 open hacktoberfest issues were indexed on Oct 16, 2026.
- About 517,632 remain unclaimed.
- Average annotated difficulty: 3.7 / 5.
- 11% of time estimates are one day or less.
- About 9,738 issues opened in the previous seven days.
- The GitHub hacktoberfest topic covers 148,820 public repositories.
- 25,097 of those carry hacktoberfest-accepted.
- TrendForge listed 46 trending projects on Oct 11, including Apollo-11, Termux, Kestra, and Bubble Tea.

Common contribution work

- Documentation improvements
- Unit tests
- i18n string wrapping
- Magic-number extraction
- Checksum or SBOM documentation
- Claims should follow project rules: claim before work, DCO sign-off (git commit -s), linked issues (Fixes #123), focused diffs, passing CI

Discovery pattern

- Search for unclaimed, unlinked issues.
- Use queries such as is:issue is:open label:"hacktoberfest" label:"good first issue" no:assignee.
- Add -linked:pr to reduce duplicated work.
- Opt-in labeling and acceptance labels still matter even though PRs no longer count for rewards.

Controversy and impact debate

- Sponsors include Tiger Data, Snowflake, MongoDB, Gauge, Solana, Render, GitHub, Sentry, Backboard.io, IBM, ElevenLabs, Paper Compute, Entire, Prior Labs, Google Cloud/Gemma, Qualcomm, Arduino, Mastra, Temporal, TLDR, Thinking Machines, .tech, and SerpApi.
- Some critics argue losing PR tracking damages the Hacktoberfest phenomenon.
- India contributors reported fewer Fests than the country's scale would suggest.
- Online participants no longer get a guaranteed T-shirt; only in-person supplies or raffle items remain.
- Organizers cite education wins: 500+ Fests in 60+ countries and 3,000 projects submitted in the first week.
- Examples cited include a Pakistan Hack Day hospital platform and a multimodal accessibility tool.
- Historic pipeline examples include freeCodeCamp growing a quiz site from 694 to 1,171 questions in one October and Meilisearch hiring a contributor days after a first contribution.
- Skeptics worry the new model trades first-PR pathways for events and cash-prize contests.
- AI-slop concerns remain year-round; some maintainers now assume large PRs may be AI-generated.
- Accessibility is host-delegated, with explicit accommodation channels in many Fests.
- No 2026 Hacktoberfest-specific demographic data were published mid-event.
- Because the event is still running, verdicts on inclusion, pipeline impact, and spam reduction remain unverified.

Best practices

For maintainers

- Use CI contribution gates: tests, no warnings, docs updates when behavior changes.
- Keep PRs roughly under 400 lines.
- Publish CONTRIBUTING.md, issue templates, required fields, and difficulty tiers.
- Audit CI/CD and consider OpenSSF Scorecards.
- Save consistent rejection messages, such as "does not meet our contribution bar."
- Define clear AI-disclosure rules.
- Require reproduction details, versions, and exploitability for security reports.

Spam and quality playbook

- Keep hacktoberfest topic opt-in.
- Use hacktoberfest-accepted acceptance labels.
- Apply review windows, spam labels, and reporting routes.
- Consider an advisory council for disputed cases.
- GitHub's 2026 PR open and interaction limits for non-write users provide infrastructure-level

throttling.

For contributors

- Claim an issue explicitly and wait for acknowledgment.
- Respect scope.
- Write tests.
- Link issues.
- Avoid cosmetic-only sweeps.
- Disclose AI use.
- Own each contribution and use the project first.
- Avoid AI-sounding, low-context submissions.

Conclusion

- Hacktoberfest 2026 separates community participation from PR volume accounting.
- Projects lose the October first-contribution flood, but gain protection from review overload.
- Contributors gain claimable work and local onboarding, but lose reward-linked contribution feedback.
- The outcome depends on unpublished metrics: Fest attendance, challenge quality, and maintainer review load.
- Reward design remains the central lever in open-source participation programs.

Sources

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